

Java + DSA Placement Roadmap

A final-year, month-by-month plan to land a good MNC job

Overall Strategy

Final year gives you roughly 10-12 months before placements begin (most MNCs recruit August-December for campus, or you apply off-campus year-round). Split prep into three phases: **Foundation** → **Application-Ready** → **Interview Mode**.

Phase 1: Foundation (Months 1-3)

Java — go deep, not surface level

- Week 1-2: OOP concepts — practice explaining with real examples (e.g. why composition over inheritance)
- Week 3-4: Collections framework internals — how HashMap works internally, ArrayList vs LinkedList tradeoffs
- Week 5-6: Exception handling, multithreading basics
- Week 7: Java 8+ — Streams, Lambdas, method references (frequently asked in interviews now)

DSA — start in parallel, don't wait

- Arrays, Strings, basic recursion — solve 3-4 problems/day
- Focus on patterns (two-pointer, sliding window) over memorizing solutions
- Target: 60-70 problems solved by end of month 3

Output check: By month 3, solve easy-medium LeetCode problems in 20-30 minutes and explain Java OOP without stumbling.

Phase 2: Application-Ready (Months 4-7)

DSA — go deeper

- LinkedList, Stacks/Queues, Trees, Graphs, then Dynamic Programming
- Aim for 150+ total problems solved by month 7
- Start timed practice to simulate real interview pressure

Build 2 solid projects

- Project 1: Spring Boot + MySQL REST API (e.g. e-commerce backend, library system) — real CRUD + auth + relationships
- Project 2: A self-initiated idea, ideally with a simple frontend, deployed (Render/Railway free tier works)
- Push clean code to GitHub with proper READMEs — this is what gets you shortlisted

Learn the surrounding stack

- SQL: joins, indexes, normalization — practice real queries, not just theory
- Git: branching, PRs, resolving conflicts

- Basic system design concepts (even freshers get asked things like "design a URL shortener")

Output check: By month 7, resume has 2 real projects, GitHub looks active, and you're comfortable with medium DSA problems.

Phase 3: Interview Mode (Months 8-12)

This is when placements/applications actually happen

- Polish resume — quantify impact where possible (e.g. "reduced query time by X%", "built API handling Y requests")
- Start mock interviews — with friends, seniors, or platforms like Pramp
- Revise DSA patterns weekly instead of learning new topics — retention matters more now
- Prep behavioral/HR answers (Tell me about yourself, why this company, a challenge you faced)

Applications

- On-campus: attend every drive that matches your interest, don't be picky early on — experience matters
- Off-campus: LinkedIn (reach out to alumni for referrals), company career pages, referral programs
- Keep a tracker of applications — don't rely on memory

Typical interview rounds at MNCs

Round	What it covers
1. Online Assessment	DSA problems, sometimes aptitude/logical reasoning
2. Technical Interview(s)	Java fundamentals, DSA, your projects, sometimes SQL
3. System Design / More Coding	Basic design for freshers, or another coding round
4. HR / Managerial	Fit, motivation, behavioral questions

A Few Things I'd Stress as a Senior Dev

- **Consistency beats intensity.** 2-3 focused hours daily for a year beats a burnout week before placements.
- **Don't skip projects for more DSA.** Interviewers remember candidates who can talk deeply about something they built.
- **Referrals are underrated.** A LinkedIn message to an alum saying "I saw you work at X, would love a referral" works more often than people expect.
- **Don't stay only in the "easy" LeetCode zone.** Growth happens in the medium zone where you're a bit uncomfortable.